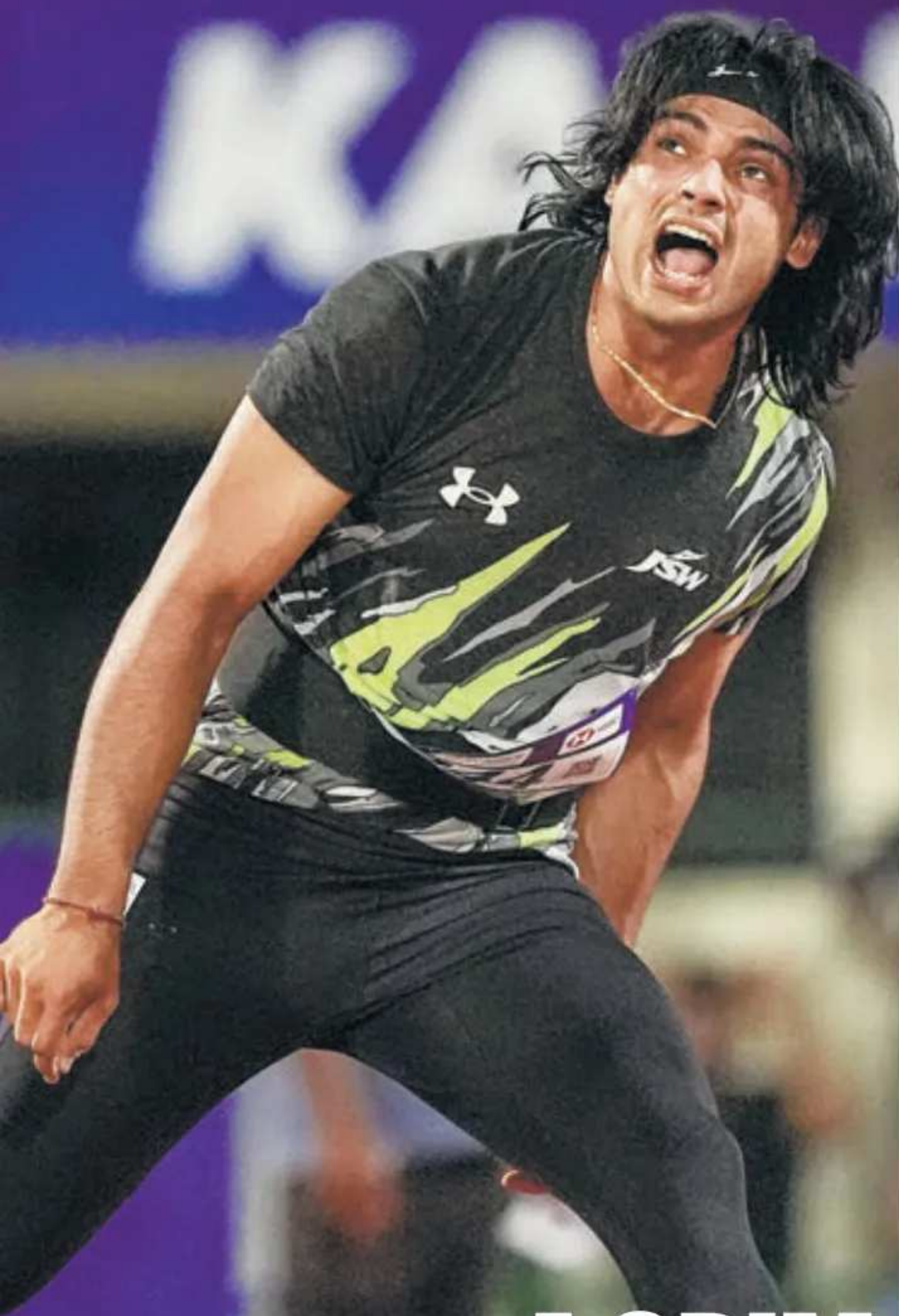




A GRIM WAKE-UP CALL

The 27th Federation Cup at Kalinga Stadium saw Neeraj Chopra's homecoming, but **not a single athlete** met the Olympic qualification standards.

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The 27th Federation Cup, held at the Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar from May 12 to 15, could have been one of the most memorable domestic athletics meetings in recent times, setting the tone for the upcoming Paris Olympics.

The entry list had a certain Neeraj Chopra amongst the participants for the men's javelin throw. The 26-year-old, India's only Olympic and World Champion in track and field, had confirmed he would take part in an event on home soil for the first time in three years.

It raised the profile of the meet and also drew attention towards those still chasing the Olympic standard in other events with less than two months remaining in the qualification cycle.

Neeraj turned up for the event less than a week after his season-opener in Doha where he finished second with 88.36m throw in the Diamond League meeting. A police vehicle escorted the star as he arrived for a light training session two hours before his event on the final day.

Considering the European competitions he is set to take part in, as he prepares for Paris, Neeraj did not push himself unnecessarily, but still won gold with his fourth and last throw of 82.27m in front of nearly two thousand spectators. He happily obliged requests for autographs and selfies too.

"It was a great feeling to compete in India after a long time. I'm happy to see so many people turning up to watch athletics," he said afterwards.

While Neeraj's homecoming did make a mark, the fact that no athlete in the capital of Odisha managed to book a spot for the Summer Games was disappointing.

In javelin itself, silver medallist Manu DP (82.06m) fell well short of the entry mark of 85.50m for Paris. Home

Leading the way: Neeraj Chopra did not push himself unnecessarily but still won gold with his fourth and last throw of 82.27m. PTI